Baselines and fair comparisons

Learn to understand, design, build, test and explain AI systems responsibly.

Project: Reproducible AI Research Study

Before you start

Recall Hypotheses and measurable outcomes. Explain why a recorded result needs its input conditions and evidence source before it can support a claim.

Plan time to read, investigate and explain. Keep predictions separate from observations.

Your mission

> Start with the target: Explain the mechanism and terminology of baselines and fair comparisons. Try the recall before opening notes.

Your learning target

I can explain the **mechanism** and terminology of **baseline**s and fair comparisons.

I can apply the stated procedure to a new case with a traceable result.

I can identify an assumption or limitation and design a revealing follow-up.

Remember before reading

Close your notes first. A rough first answer helps us choose the right starting point; it is not a score for your ability.

Without opening the old lesson, explain one key idea from Hypotheses and measurable outcomes. Give an example and a mistake that the idea helps you avoid.

Without opening the old lesson, explain one key idea from Replication and reproduction. Give an example and a mistake that the idea helps you avoid.

Without opening the old lesson, explain one key idea from Reading a research claim. Give an example and a mistake that the idea helps you avoid.

After trying, check the relevant lesson or ask your teacher. Change the part of your explanation that the **evidence** shows was wrong.

This week you will practise:

Explain the **mechanism** and terminology of **baseline**s and fair comparisons

Apply the stated procedure to a new case with a traceable result

Identify an assumption or limitation and design a revealing follow-up

Retrieve what you already know

Recall Hypotheses and measurable outcomes. Explain why a recorded result needs its **input** conditions and **evidence** source before it can support a claim.

> **My starting explanation**

This week's end goal

Explain **baseline**s and fair comparisons using the records and boundaries of this fictional investigation.

Notice the evidence

> Investigate the supplied Baselines and fair comparisons case. Separate observations, given facts and assumptions before choosing an explanation.

Fair **baseline**s use credible procedures on matched **evidence** and resource conditions. A weak arbitrary reference can exaggerate improvement.

Begin by writing the question the procedure is intended to answer. Identify the information already supplied, the information it will produce and the information still missing.

These are constructed classroom examples; they do not require live accounts, private records or an external service. Do not treat a plausible explanation as a measured outcome.

> **List the given facts and one fact that is not supplied.**

See how it works

> Follow the mechanism for Baselines and fair comparisons. Connect each labelled input, deciding step and result.

For a room-reporting study use manual authoritative lookup or a deterministic same-room rule, not random room names. Match cases, available sources and scoring.

Baselines and fair comparisons — evidence trace

INPUT AND SCOPE	CHECK OR CALCULATION	CONCLUSION AND LIMIT
Assistant gets current register; baseline gets an obsolete one. Assistant scores higher.	For a room-reporting study use manual authoritative lookup or a deterministic same-room rule, not random room names.	Source freshness is confounded with procedure. Provide both the same eligible current sources or report the unequal comparison without isolating method.

The figure connects this chapter's worked input, declared procedure and result. Read the complete worked reasoning for qualifiers and intermediate steps; the abbreviated labels do not replace that reasoning.

Before applying the procedure, write its units, denominator or decision boundary where relevant. A partner should be able to repeat each step using the same **input**s.

If a required **input** is absent or violates the stated contract, record that condition explicitly instead of quietly replacing it with a convenient value.

Connect the picture and the explanation

Point to the **input**, the deciding step and the result in this week's visual. Explain the same step in ordinary words. A picture helps when you can say what each part represents.

STUDENT LESSON · 4 OF 18

Compare the cases

> Compare the supplied cases for Baselines and fair comparisons. Identify the detail that changes the conclusion.

Compare a familiar case with a changed case

Assistant gets current register; **baseline** gets an obsolete one. Assistant scores higher. Show the intermediate steps and give the conclusion with its scope.

Keep the procedure fixed. Explain what changed in the inputs and result.

Change one thing in the pictured case

Change one thing

Change: Give B the answer key before testing.

Predicted result

Prediction: The resulting comparison is invalid as unseen evaluation.

Why the result follows

Reason: B would receive privileged information that A did not receive.

STUDENT LESSON · 5 OF 18

Words that unlock the idea

Use the vocabulary of Baselines and fair comparisons to explain a concrete decision, rather than only memorising definitions.

Word	Meaning
Baseline	A relevant reference procedure
Matched comparison	A comparison with aligned task conditions
Resource budget	The permitted time or computation

Use two terms to explain a step in this week's example.

STUDENT LESSON · 6 OF 18

Follow a worked example

> Follow the worked trace for Baselines and fair comparisons, predict a step, then compare with its explanation.

Assistant gets current register; **baseline** gets an obsolete one. Assistant scores higher.

Source freshness is confounded with procedure. Provide both the same eligible current sources or report the unequal comparison without isolating method.

Worked explanation · Baselines and fair comparisons

Compare the intermediate **evidence** with the final statement. Explain why each number or decision follows from the stated **input**s.

The conclusion belongs to this scenario and procedure; changing the **input**s, evaluation population or authority can change what it establishes. Retain the raw record so a later revision can be compared honestly.

Learn from the worked case

Cover the result before checking it. Say what is given, choose the procedure, and follow one step at a time. Then uncover the result and explain your first mismatch. Ask why a step is allowed, not only what number it produces.

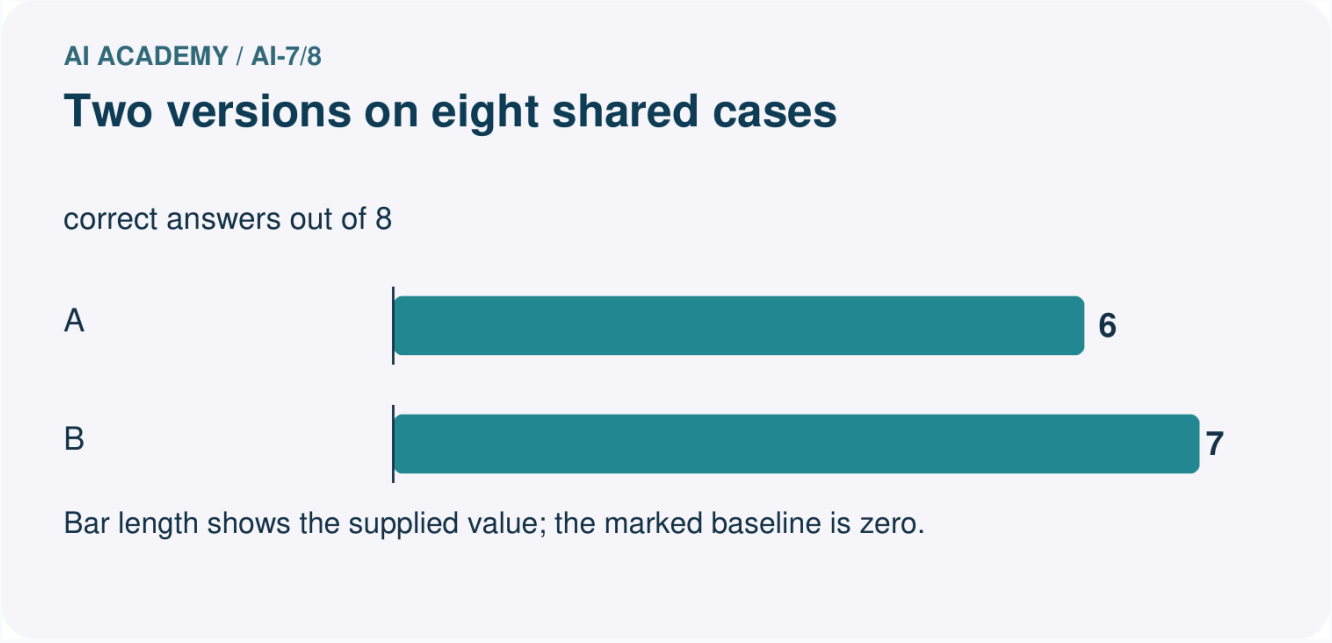
A pictorial worked case: Baselines and fair comparisons

A **baseline** deserves a fair chance. Two classifiers answer the same eight fixed questions with the same allowed sources.

The facts we will use

Supplied facts

Simple rule A: 6/8 correct. New model B: 7/8 correct. No test case is used to tune either version.



Follow the labelled picture with the matching explanation. Open the vector diagram

AI ACADEMY / AI-7/8

Baselines and fair comparisons

Start with the supplied facts

Follow each arrow. Ask which fact allows the next step.



1. Declare baseline

A uses a simple documented rule rather than an intentionally weak placeholder.



2. Measure fairly

A is 75%; B is 87.5% on the same eight cases.



3. Interpret cautiously

B adds one correct case here; compare resources and failure types too.

CHANGE ONE THING

Give B the answer key before testing.

Explain the changed result using the matching lesson.

Follow the labelled picture with the matching explanation. Open the vector diagram

Read the picture one step at a time

STEP	WHAT HAPPENS AND WHY
1. Declare baseline	A uses a simple documented rule rather than an intentionally weak placeholder.
2. Measure fairly	A is 75%; B is 87.5% on the same eight cases.
3. Interpret cautiously	B adds one correct case here; compare resources and failure types too.

Match each pictured step to the supplied facts. This is a worked teaching case, not an independent assessment.

Why this result follows

Why the result follows

A **baseline** anchors the claim of improvement. Fair comparison keeps information access, cases and scoring aligned while allowing the declared method difference.

What this example does not establish

Keep the stated limit

Eight cases do not establish a stable advantage or statistical significance.

Keep the stated limit

Read the labelled picture: Calculate 6/8 and 7/8 correctness and name the one-case gain. Why is giving B the answer key incompatible with an unseen comparison to the simple **baseline**?

Keep the stated limit

Change one thing: Give B the answer key before testing. Predict the result before checking the explanation. What remains the same?

STUDENT LESSON · 7 OF 18

Find and repair a mistake

> Find the unsupported step in the Baselines and fair comparisons claim and explain a repair using the supplied evidence.

A **baseline** is credible relative to the task, not merely a procedure easy to outperform.

Check the claim against the facts

A useful check asks what would make the reasoning fail. Distinguish a failure to execute the declared procedure from a weakness in the procedure itself.

The first may require a correction; the second requires an explicitly revised method and new **evidence**. Preserve unsuccessful cases so an improved result cannot hide the original problem.

Guided: restate the worked result, then name the assumption or limitation that prevents a broader conclusion.

Locate the earliest unsupported step

A report omits this qualification: A **baseline** is credible relative to the task, not merely a procedure easy to outperform. Explain how omitting it could change a reader's interpretation, and write an accurate replacement.

State one repair and the checks you would rerun.

STUDENT LESSON · 8 OF 18

Practise together

> Practise Baselines and fair comparisons with support, then explain the deciding step in your own words.

Explain the weekly **mechanism** in your own words. Use the worked scenario to name its **input**, decision rule and **output**.

Guided: restate the worked result, then name the assumption or limitation that prevents a broader conclusion.

Explain your prediction to a partner before comparing results.

Practise with less help: Trace the worked case

Use workbook W2 for the connected example "**Baseline**s and fair comparisons". First fill the **input** and rule boxes. Try the middle steps before asking for a hint. After a hint, try the next step yourself.

Plan	Do	Check
What is given? Which rule or procedure applies?	Record each intermediate step.	Does the result follow? What remains unknown?

Explain your trace to a partner. Your partner points to one step to check. Swap roles on the next case. Each person writes their own explanation.

Check your reasoning

Use the worked case for **Baseline**s and fair comparisons. Proposed explanation: "The worked result establishes every future case". Decide whether this explanation is supported.

Point to the step or supplied fact that decides; explain your repair if needed.

Answer on your own before discussion. If you are unsure, say which step you need help with.

Explain the picture

> Calculate 6/8 and 7/8 correctness and name the one-case gain. Why is giving B the answer key incompatible with an unseen comparison to the simple **baseline**?

My explanation using a pictured step and the given facts

This is supported practice. Keep the separately named independent case for an attempt before feedback.

STUDENT LESSON · 9 OF 18

Run the investigation

> Investigate Baselines and fair comparisons. Record the prediction, actual observation or labelled paper trace, explanation and next test separately.

Predict, investigate and preserve the evidence

Assistant gets current register; **baseline** gets an obsolete one. Assistant scores higher. Show the intermediate steps and give the conclusion with its scope.

Record	Your evidence
Given input and fixed rule	
Prediction before checking	
Actual result, or “not run”	

Record	Your evidence
First mismatch and one explanation	
Boundary or missing input and expected response	

On paper, trace the supplied procedure. If code is provided, predict before running it in a local practice file. Never write an expected answer as though it were an observed run.

Plan → try → check

Before trying: what do I expect, and why? While trying: which step could first go wrong? Afterwards: what did I actually observe, and what should change? Keep “not run” if you only traced the procedure.

STUDENT LESSON · 10 OF 18

Build your understanding

> Move from recall to tracing, diagnosis and transfer in Baselines and fair comparisons. Explain why each step is justified.

Explain → apply → challenge

Explain the weekly **mechanism** in your own words. Use the worked scenario to name its **input**, decision rule and **output**.

A report omits this qualification: A **baseline** is credible relative to the task, not merely a procedure easy to outperform. Explain how omitting it could change a reader's interpretation, and write an accurate replacement.

For the worked scenario, propose one additional case that could reveal a failure, describe its expected outcome before running it, and explain what would need to remain fixed for a fair comparison.

Do not reuse W4 as a new final test after receiving feedback.

Explain which evidence supports your conclusion and which claim remains unproved.

STUDENT LESSON · 11 OF 18

Connect your project

> Apply this week's idea to Reproducible AI Research Study. Keep an annotated decision and the evidence supporting it.

Add a labelled **baseline**s and fair comparisons **evidence** sheet to Reproducible AI Research Study. Show how you can explain the **mechanism** and terminology of **baseline**s and fair comparisons.

Use the supplied fictional case and keep its **input**s, intermediate steps, calculation or **prediction**, and limitation. Connect this record to last week's record; a matching answer without a trace is insufficient.

Project evidence	Record
Component and version	
Inputs permitted at prediction time	
Trace and comparison with earlier work	
Failure, limit and human review	

Evidence for your project

For the Reproducible AI Research Study, retain an annotated worked trace and the changed-case reasoning. Connect the claim to its records, units and assumptions so another investigator can challenge or reproduce it.

STUDENT LESSON · 12 OF 18

Show what you know

> Use a genuinely new case for independent evidence. Previously discussed examples remain practice; use the separately named independent case before feedback.

Complete the supported workbook tasks before attempting W4 independently. Record any hints or help used. After feedback, use the teacher's fresh retry rather than copying the earlier answer.

For a project, select a relevant new case, predict the outcome from the declared rule and preserve the result alongside any revision.

> **Exit: propose one revealing change to the worked scenario. State the expected outcome and the evidence that would make you revise your explanation.**

For the worked scenario, propose one additional case that could reveal a failure, describe its expected outcome before running it, and explain what would need to remain fixed for a fair comparison.

Do not reuse W4 as a new final test after receiving feedback.

My limited claim and a useful next check

STUDENT LESSON · 13 OF 18

Study a complete case

Revisit the complete Baselines and fair comparisons case for supported practice. Repeated examples do not become fresh assessments.

Complete evidence record

Baselines and fair comparisons — evidence trace

INPUT AND SCOPE	CHECK OR CALCULATION	CONCLUSION AND LIMIT
Assistant gets current register; baseline gets an obsolete one. Assistant scores higher.	For a room-reporting study use manual authoritative lookup or a deterministic same-room rule, not random room names.	Source freshness is confounded with procedure. Provide both the same eligible current sources or report the unequal comparison without isolating method.

The figure connects this chapter's worked input, declared procedure and result. Read the complete worked reasoning for qualifiers and intermediate steps; the abbreviated labels do not replace that reasoning.

Follow the **input** through the stated procedure to its result. Cover the result first, predict it, then explain every intermediate step. The text/table accompanies the figure so the example can be read without colour.

My complete trace of the worked case

STUDENT LESSON · 14 OF 18

Try a new case independently

Attempt the reserved new case before feedback. Record support; the earlier examples below remain additional practice.

Independent case: Apply a new case independently

Model uses12 seconds and **baseline**2 on each case. Task has a3-second budget. How should results be framed?

My independent explanation, trace and limits

Attempt this case before feedback. Record any help. Earlier examples below are further practice; a case already practised with feedback cannot establish fresh transfer.

Attempt this without hints

> Model uses12 seconds and **baseline**2 on each case. Task has a3-second budget. How should results be framed?

My independent procedure, result and limitation

Record support used: none, hint or teacher explanation. After feedback, a different case is needed to demonstrate independence.

Use feedback to improve

Attempt the independent case before hints. Record whether you worked alone, used a hint or followed a model. After feedback, fix the first unsupported step and explain why it changed.

A later check uses a changed case, not a copied answer.

STUDENT LESSON · 15 OF 18

Your lesson route

> Use this map to navigate Baselines and fair comparisons, connect the goals to tasks and keep one evidence record for each attempt.

Start with this question: A **baseline** deserves a fair chance. Two classifiers answer the same eight fixed questions with the same allowed sources.

By the end, I can	How I will show it
Explain the mechanism and terminology of baselines and fair comparisons	Explain the deciding step, show a trace or test, and state one limit.
Apply the stated procedure to a new case with a traceable result	Explain the deciding step, show a trace or test, and state one limit.
Identify an assumption or limitation and design a revealing follow-up	Explain the deciding step, show a trace or test, and state one limit.

Remember → watch and explain → try with help → investigate → try independently → keep project **evidence**. Your teacher may spread this lesson across several classes.

Keep your first **prediction**. Compare it with what the **evidence** shows and explain any change.

STUDENT LESSON · 16 OF 18

Finish and return

> Explain Baselines and fair comparisons without notes, identify a remaining question and plan a later check with a changed case.

Close your notes. Explain this goal in your own words: Explain the **mechanism** and terminology of **baseline**s and fair comparisons

My deciding step, evidence and one remaining question

If you are unsure, return to the worked picture and explain one arrow. If you are ready, change an **input** or assumption and justify your **prediction**.

Save your workbook **evidence**. At the next review, try a different case before opening your old answer.

STUDENT LESSON · 17 OF 18

Supported practice, repair and portfolio

> Attempt supported questions before using hints or feedback. Review a missing building block, then keep the completed work.

Use this supported practice once, in the browser or on paper. Keep the reserved independent assessment for a separate first attempt before teacher feedback.

A **baseline** deserves a fair chance. Two classifiers answer the same eight fixed questions with the same allowed sources.

Practice 1: explain the deciding evidence

Which labelled step matches this detail? B adds one correct case here; compare resources and failure types too.

1. Declare **baseline**

2. Interpret cautiously

3. Measure fairly

My selected conclusion, deciding fact and explanation

Hint · try first

Hint if needed: Read the steps in the pictorial case. Match the supplied detail to the stage that performs or records it.

Feedback · compare after trying

After your attempt, compare with the supported explanation: Interpret cautiously B adds one correct case here; compare resources and failure types too. A **baseline** anchors the claim of improvement.

Fair comparison keeps information access, cases and scoring aligned while allowing the declared method difference.

Practice 2: explain the deciding evidence

Changed case · predict first

Changed-case practice: Give B the answer key before testing. Which conclusion is supported by the supplied facts?

1. We can decide the result without examining the changed **input** or the procedure.

2. The resulting comparison is invalid as unseen evaluation.

3. This one example guarantees correct results for every future **input**.

My selected conclusion, deciding fact and explanation

Hint · try first

Hint if needed: Use the changed condition and the deciding step in the pictorial trace. The answer must say what follows from those facts.

Feedback · compare after trying

After your attempt, compare with the supported explanation: The resulting comparison is invalid as unseen evaluation. B would receive privileged information that A did not receive.

Repair a missing building block

Review Hypotheses and measurable outcomes (ai-7/7). Goal: Explain the **mechanism** and terminology of hypotheses and measurable outcomes. Short practice: Name the predicted outcome and how unsupported is scored.

If B sounds friendlier but ties A's unsupported count, does the recorded improvement hypothesis receive support?. Return to this week and explain what you changed.

Review Replication and reproduction (ai-7/5). Goal: Explain the **mechanism** and terminology of replication and reproduction. Short practice: Calculate the scores from the original and new four-record sets.

Which activity reproduces saved analysis, which repeats the protocol, and why does a different rerun of the original data need investigation?. Return to this week and explain what you changed.

Review Reading a research claim (ai-7/2). Goal: Explain the **mechanism** and terminology of reading a research claim. Short practice: Calculate the **baseline** and new rates for 2/10 and 4/10.

Explain both twice the rate and the percentage-point change, and say why neither measures every learner’s improvement.. Return to this week and explain what you changed.

Keep your completed work

Use Download completed work in the hosted lesson to export your answers, reflections, practice feedback and code-run **evidence**. Open the HTML copy to read or print it.

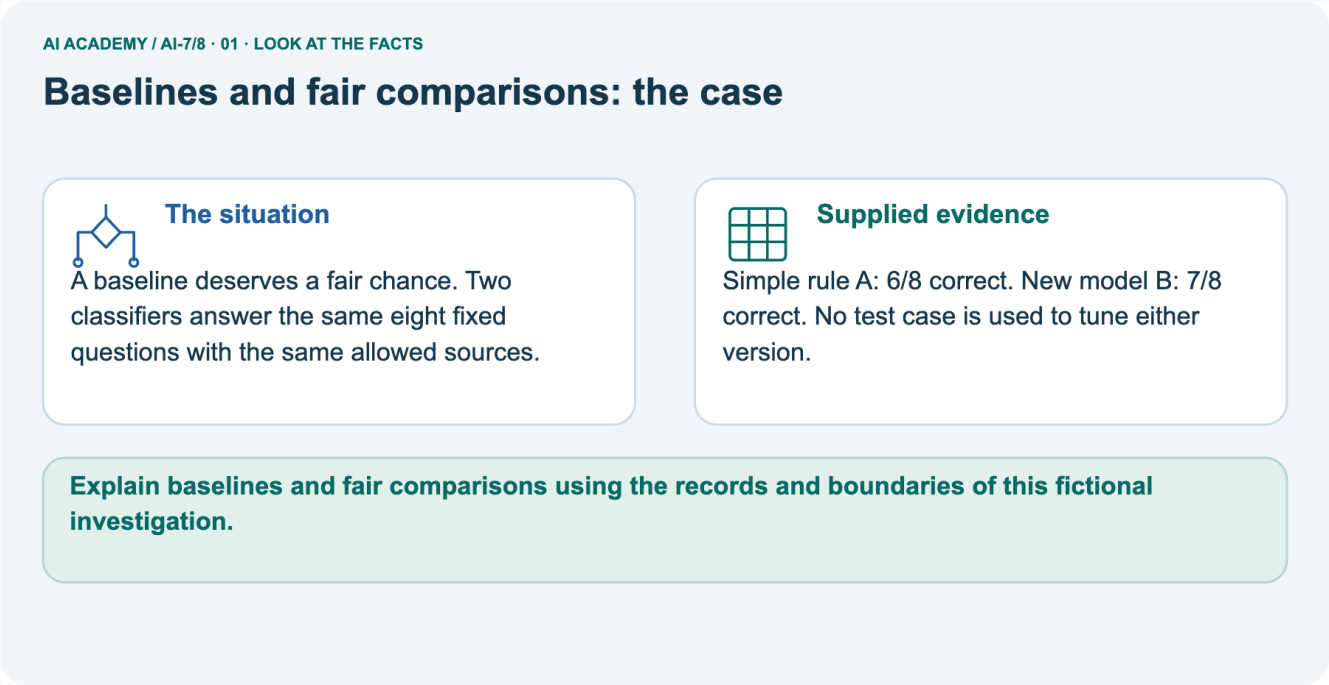
Drafts stay in this browser when storage is available; clear drafts on a shared device.

STUDENT LESSON · 18 OF 18

Visual concept journey

> Explain each Baselines and fair comparisons graphic using its labels, deciding evidence and relevant limitation.

01. Baselines and fair comparisons: the case



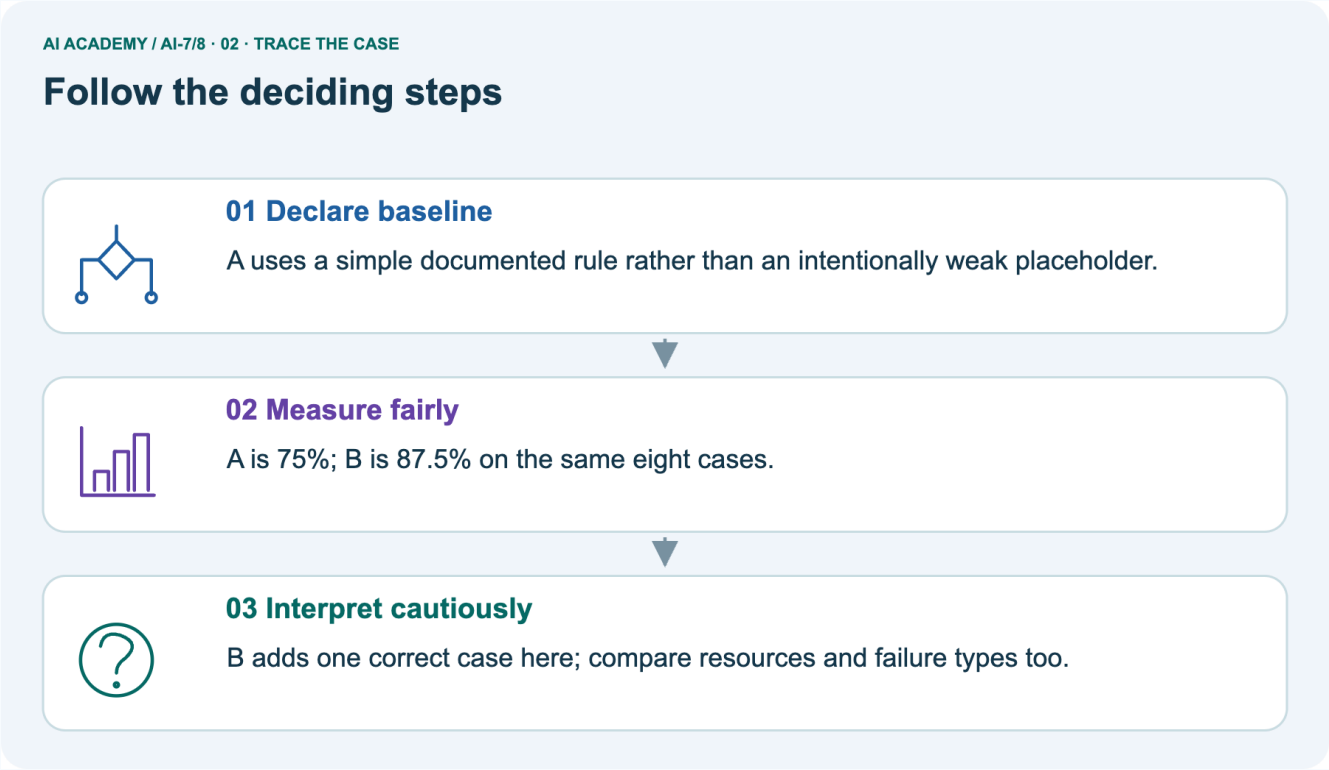
Follow the labelled picture with the matching explanation. Open the vector diagram

A **baseline** deserves a fair chance. Two classifiers answer the same eight fixed questions with the same allowed sources. Supplied facts: Simple rule A: 6/8 correct. New model B: 7/8 correct.

No test case is used to tune either version.

> Point to the given fact that matters most. Explain why it matters.

02. Follow the deciding steps

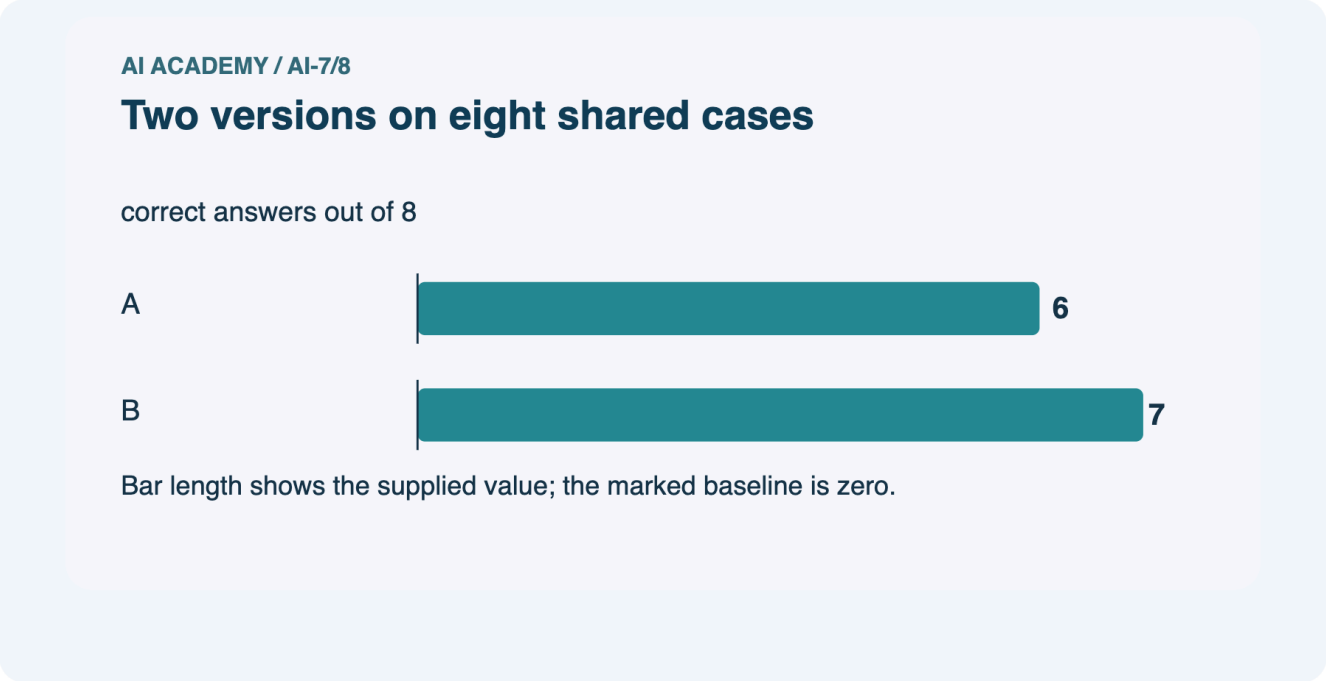


Follow the labelled picture with the matching explanation. Open the vector diagram

Declare **baseline**: A uses a simple documented rule rather than an intentionally weak placeholder. → Measure fairly: A is 75%; B is 87.5% on the same eight cases. → Interpret cautiously: B adds one correct case here; compare resources and failure types too.

> Point to each numbered stage and explain which recorded **input** it uses.

03. Two versions on eight shared cases

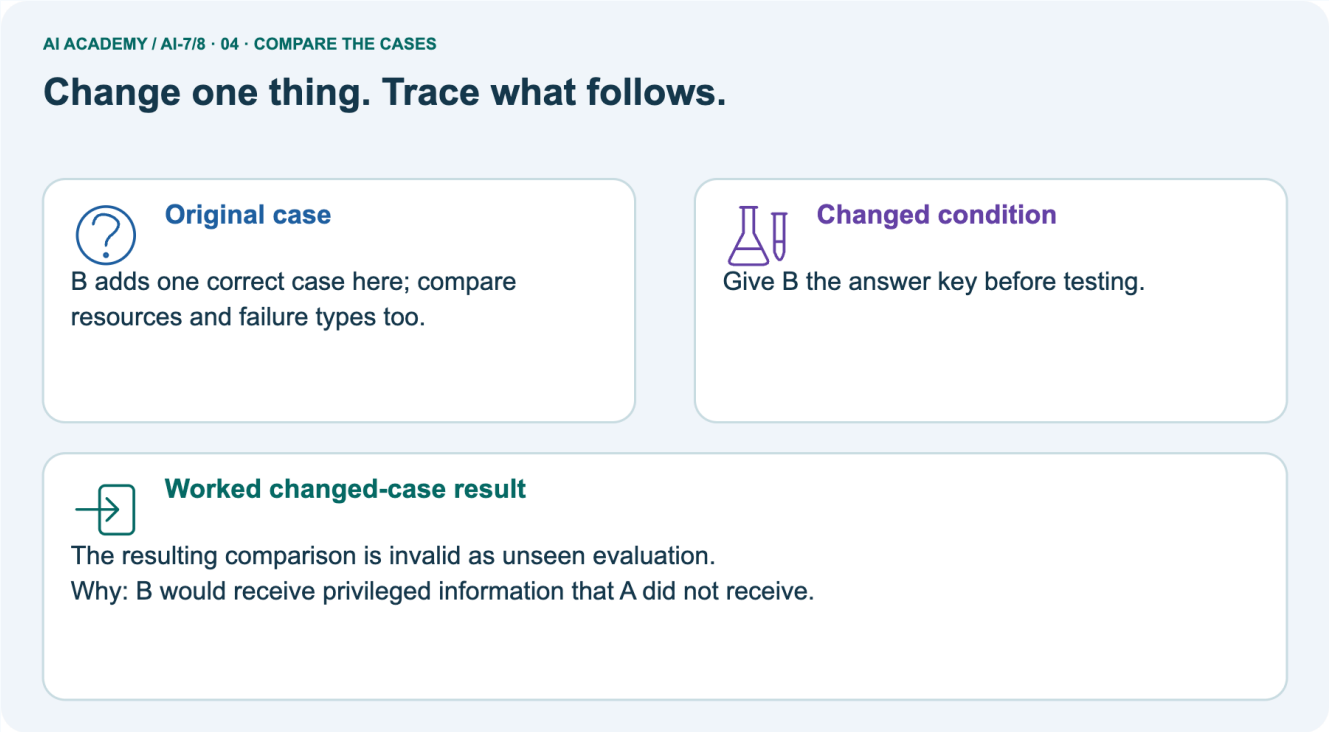


Follow the labelled picture with the matching explanation. Open the vector diagram

Two versions on eight shared cases. Units: correct answers out of 8. A: 6. B: 7.

> Read the labels and values. Explain the relationship the model shows.

04. Change one thing. Trace what follows.



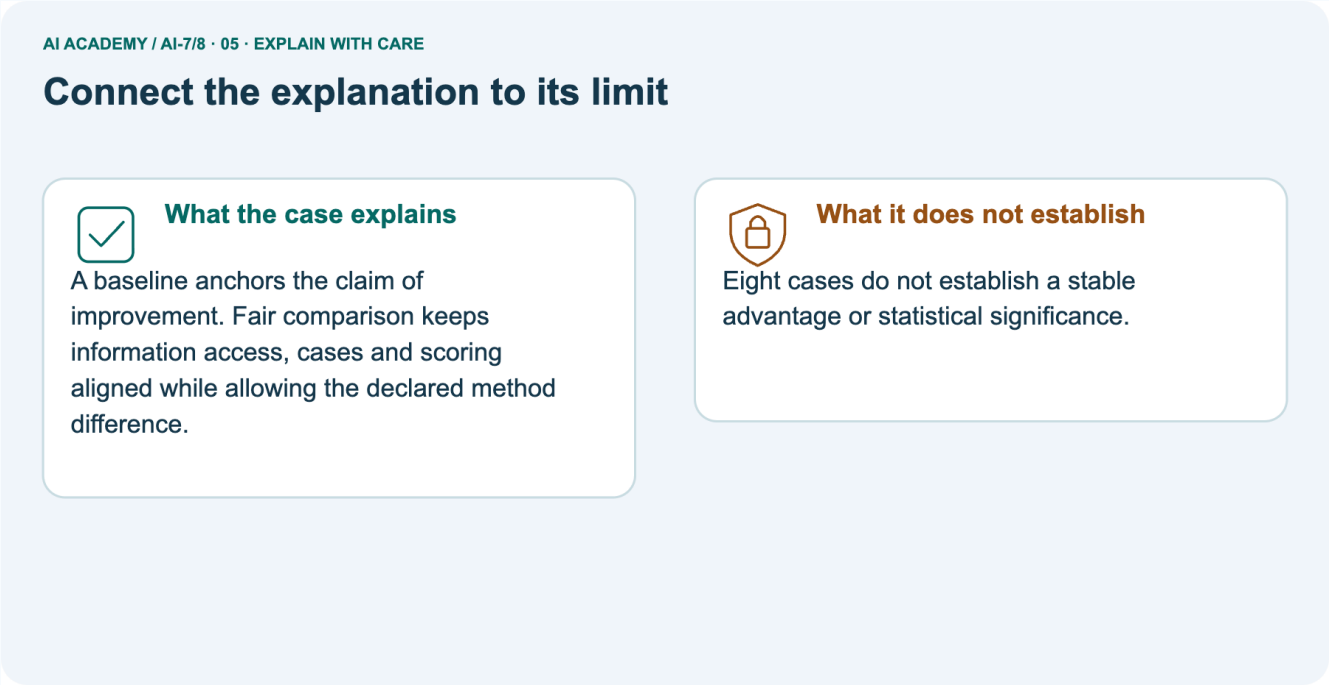
Follow the labelled picture with the matching explanation. Open the vector diagram

Original case: B adds one correct case here; compare resources and failure types too. Changed condition: Give B the answer key before testing. Expected result: The resulting comparison is invalid as unseen evaluation.

Reason: B would receive privileged information that A did not receive.

> Predict before checking the worked changed-case result. Name what changed and what the supplied facts allow you to conclude.

05. Connect the explanation to its limit



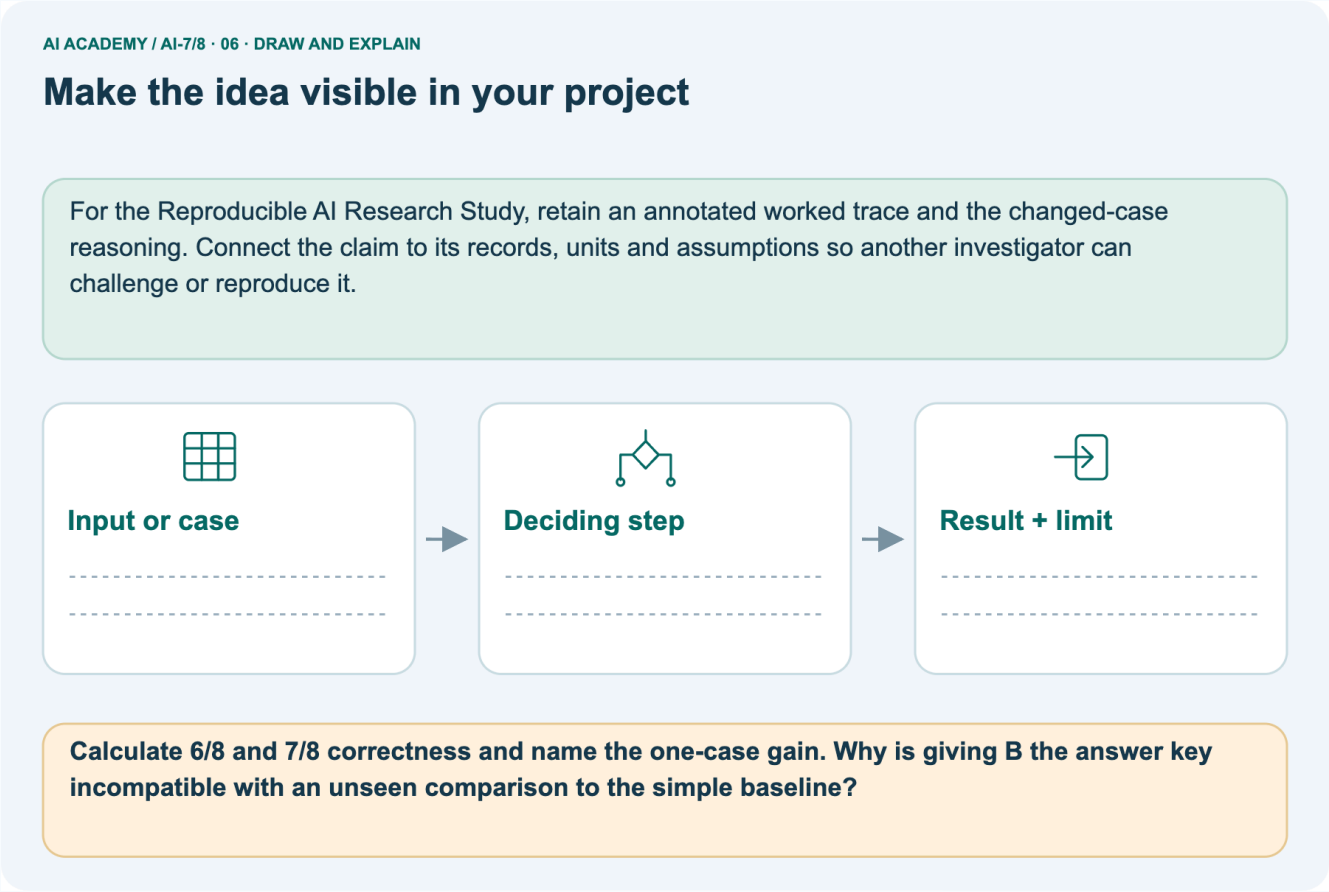
Follow the labelled picture with the matching explanation. Open the vector diagram

A **baseline** anchors the claim of improvement. Fair comparison keeps information access, cases and scoring aligned while allowing the declared method difference.

Limit: Eight cases do not establish a stable advantage or statistical significance.

> Explain the case, then point to a limit on the claim.

06. Make the idea visible in your project



Follow the labelled picture with the matching explanation. Open the vector diagram

For the Reproducible AI Research Study, retain an annotated worked trace and the changed-case reasoning. Connect the claim to its records, units and assumptions so another investigator can challenge or reproduce it.

Draw your **input**, deciding step, result and limit. Supported question: Calculate 6/8 and 7/8 correctness and name the one-case gain. Why is giving B the answer key incompatible with an unseen comparison to the simple **baseline**?

> Draw your project trace and justify the deciding step using **evidence**.

Save or print your responses for your portfolio. Progress and drafts on the hosted website stay in the current browser. Use only fictional or teacher-approved data.